THE SHE LIST

Local Flavour

Manisha Bhasin, *57*
Corporate Executive Chef, ITC



Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**

THE TASTIEST FOOD DOESN'T HAVE TO be complicated. "Just one or two good-quality ingredients can make a dish shine," says chef Manisha Bhasin who, for over three decades now, has been championing sustainable local food. Manish learned about green culinary practices and sourcing of local ingredients and implemented them in her kitchens at a time when most chefs were flying in food from across continents, and picking barnyard millet over quinoa was quite rare. In fact, she recounts that back in the late '90s when she was in charge of the kitchen at Westview by ITC Maurya in Delhi, the menu was not even a printed laminated sheet but written on a blackboard. "Be open and receptive to all ideas and critiques. I started as a Western cuisine chef and over the years launched many brands for ITC hotels, starting from Panasian, Westview, Ottimo, Dehlnavi and many more," she says.

For Manisha, sustainability extends beyond food as well, like in the championing of millets. Her team was in charge of many of the dishes presented to delegates at the G20 summit in Delhi this year and the millet flour ones were quite a hit. "Millets might be popular today but we have been featuring them on our menu for years now and they have always been received well by diners," she says. At ITC hotels, various such initiatives to make local ingredients and artisanal heritage recipes popular have been introduced such as 'Mighty Millet' and 'Still Made Here'. In order to encourage local farmers, the ITC kitchens also source produce from within a 100 km radius.

ACCOMPLISHMENT
For the chef's inexhaustible passion in promoting local ingredients, cuisines

Bhasin's years of research on Dehlvi food—from four major communities: Kayastha, Vaish, Muslim and immigrant Punjabi—has made the cuisine a signature one at ITC Maurya today. And her advice to young chefs: "I would say, focus on one step at a time, learn the basics before you go on the path of inventive food. Understand the food, its philosophy and master a cuisine. The basic science of all cuisines is the same, the only difference is the ingredients. Once you perfect the basics of gastronomy, perfecting a cuisine will not be too difficult." ■

–Sonali Acharjee

KITCHEN CONFIDENTIAL

"As head chef, it is important to be sensitive to your team's aspirations and requirements and be a mentor to get the best out of them"

POTTERING AROUND **Loves gardening and tries to grow her own vegetables as far as possible**